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BRIEFING NOTE

Afghan Women's Engagement with the Taliban Authorities

Key Findings



Woman meets a local official in the Maimana governor's office (Credit: Elise Blanchard)

Key messages

- **Afghan women are actively negotiating space within Taliban governance.** Despite severe restrictions, they continue to engage in negotiations (both directly and through intermediaries) to sustain their public participation, leveraging personal and professional networks and savvy adaptations to carve out space for themselves.
- **Engagement with women varies widely across the administration.** While the Taliban impose centralised decrees restricting women's participation, enforcement is highly inconsistent. Some more pragmatic officials quietly permit certain banned activities, while others enforce bans rigidly. Women's ability to negotiate access depends on sector, location, and the personal discretion of individual officials.
- **Women's participation is fragile, contingent, and constrained.** The concessions Afghan women secure — whether business licenses, exemptions for employment, or informal tolerance — are often tenuous and reversible. These gains depend on shifting political dynamics, the risks individual officials are willing to take, and the ability of women to frame their activities in ways acceptable to the Taliban.
- **International actors must support women's resilience without increasing their risk.** Donors should prioritise discreet, flexible support that aligns with Afghan women's realities. This includes funding women's networks, tailoring aid to sectoral variations, and avoiding actions that could draw harmful scrutiny.

Introduction

Since the Taliban's return to power in August 2021, Afghan women have faced severe restrictions on their rights and public participation. Formal decrees have banned women from education beyond primary school, employment in key sectors, and many forms of public life. Despite these constraints, Afghan women continue to negotiate with the Taliban to sustain participation in public life.

Based on 68 interviews with Afghan women, Afghan officials, and other key informants, this study explores the scope and effectiveness of these negotiations. It examines how Afghan women negotiate with the Taliban for public inclusion and under what conditions these negotiations yield tangible gains.

Contrary to widespread assumptions that the Taliban do not engage with women at all or only very rarely, this research finds that engagement does occur (though its nature and extent vary significantly). At the same time, there is wide variation in how women engage with Taliban officials, from formal meetings and approvals to indirect contacts and tacit agreements sustaining higher-risk work. This research finds that women's engagement with the Taliban is not a passive acceptance of restrictions (nor is it an endorsement of Taliban governance) but a dynamic process of self-protection, requiring constant adaptation and support.

Context and overview

The Taliban's governance combines centralised decree-making with decentralised enforcement, leading to substantial local variations in how restrictions are imposed. While edicts from the Supreme Leader are rigidly enforced, policies issued at the ministerial level often allow room for interpretation, negotiation, and circumvention.

Women's negotiations within Taliban-controlled Afghanistan depends on **four key variables**:

- **Sectoral acceptance:** Some fields, such as healthcare and private business, are more tol-

erated tolerated than others, such as NGO work or human rights advocacy.

- **The issuer of restrictions:** Supreme Leader decrees are rarely negotiable, whereas ministerial or local decisions, whether written or verbal, allow for more flexibility.
- **Area of enforcement:** Provincial and district-level Taliban authorities apply rules inconsistently, with some officials adopting a pragmatic approach and others rigidly enforcing bans.
- **Individual discretion:** Some Taliban officials quietly support women's continued presence in certain controversial sectors, while others are risk-averse or ideologically opposed.

Within this shifting landscape, Afghan women engage in daily acts of negotiation to carve out space for themselves in a governance system that seeks their exclusion and erasure.

Negotiating strategies and adaptations

While this study found that Afghan women employ diverse strategies to sustain their engagement, these can be broken down into three primary modes of negotiation:

Direct engagement

Some women negotiate face-to-face with officials, often accompanied by a mahram (male chaperone) to comply with Taliban-imposed conditions. These negotiations tend to focus on securing formal permissions, such as business licenses or local approvals. Women tend to leverage pre-existing relationships with the Taliban, allowing them to navigate bureaucratic hurdles or cultivate new links through their personal, ethnic or community ties. In some cases, women cultivate goodwill through services or entrepreneurial activities targeting female relatives of the Taliban. In other cases, women mobilise extended familial or professional ties.

Indirect engagement

When direct engagement is impossible or risky, women often rely on male intermediaries (such as

community elders, former Republic officials, religious leaders, or Taliban-affiliated figures) to advocate on their behalf. These intermediaries use their relationships with the Taliban to navigate the bureaucracy. Business and professional collectives (such as the Afghan Women's Chamber of Commerce and Industry) act as collective negotiating platforms, allowing women to coordinate joint appeals to the Taliban.

Digital and remote negotiation

Some women use WhatsApp and other digital channels to communicate with Taliban authorities, particularly for administrative approvals or problem-solving. This mode of engagement provides a middle ground between direct and indirect negotiation, allowing women more agency while reducing physical risk (though some officials are reluctant to engage over WhatsApp for fear of the contact appearing inappropriate).

Some women, of course, do not feel that they can engage with the Taliban authorities at all. They tend to either continue to operate informally (avoiding Taliban registration to evade scrutiny) or cease operations entirely due to fear of retaliation, harassment or restrictions.

Adaptations to restrictions

In addition to the above, Afghan women have adapted their activities to Taliban constraints. Common adaptations include:

Sectoral shifts

Moving away from banned professions (e.g., NGO work) to tolerated activities (e.g., private business, providing female education within madrassas). Private sector activities and service delivery, especially health work, are seen as the most widely accepted.

Operational changes

In the *kafeel* system, a male representative is appointed as the legal head of an organisation, while a woman retains *de facto* leadership. This can be a risky strategy: while some women retain operational control under this system, others experience a gradual loss of influence as male

representatives assume greater decision-making power or misrepresent women's interests.

Narrative reframing

Successful engagement relies on collaboration. Women, or their interlocutors, often present activities in more acceptable terms to avoid triggering Taliban opposition. "We say we are helping women with skills training, which is true," one woman said. "But we don't use the word 'empowerment.' We say 'supporting families.' That way, the Taliban accept it."

Discreet organising

Women often rely on networks to find support and share information. Some NGOs and formal networks support these exchanges, while others rely on informal connections.

Keeping a low profile

To avoid attracting negative attention, many women interviewed said they increasingly refrain from public advocacy, media interviews, and international events with Taliban officials or press coverage.

Despite mounting restrictions, these adaptations reflect how women continue to carve out space in the few remaining avenues available for their public participation. Nevertheless, these adaptations have not reversed structural exclusion but have merely slowed women's erasure.

Concessions and Variability

The study finds that concessions from the Taliban fall along a spectrum, ranging from formal approvals (more durable) to informal tolerance (fragile and highly contingent). These include:

Formal approvals

- Licenses for women-owned enterprises.
- Memoranda of Understanding for Ministry-approved programmes in "acceptable" sectors (e.g., healthcare, vocational training).
- Official exemptions for certain women to continue working in specific roles or sectors.

Informal tolerance:

- Officials "looking the other way" rather than actively enforcing restrictions.
- Unofficial local allowances for women's activities in specific areas.
- Permission for specific activities based on personal relationships with officials.

While some Taliban officials recognise the pragmatic benefits of allowing women to work in banned areas, their accommodation is inconsistent and dependent on circumstance, sector and location. Women rarely receive concessions if their request contradicts a Supreme Leader decree, as violations of these decrees carry severe consequences for Taliban officials. Ministerial policies offer more room for negotiation, as Taliban officials face lower risks than when dealing with Supreme Leader decrees and have more room for interpretation. In some cases, ministerial policies contradict each other, allowing women to leverage intra-Taliban manoeuvring to secure exceptions.

As this suggests, officials' personal beliefs and risk perceptions significantly influence concessions. Some officials prioritise political pragmatism over rigid ideological adherence, especially when concessions align with broader governance priorities. Some will even intervene when women face opposition from security agencies or other actors for approved activities. But others enforce stricter policies than required or refuse to meet with women altogether.

Recommendations

This research underscores the critical need for nuanced, pragmatic international support that aligns with the realities of women's engagement in Taliban-run Afghanistan. Afghan women's ability to negotiate space within Taliban governance has helped sustain essential services and economic activity while preserving avenues for future political and social inclusion. Their strategies demonstrate agency, resilience, and adaptability, challenging simplistic narratives of their victimhood.

The international community can better acknowledge and support their efforts while avoiding actions that increase risks for Afghan women. By investing more in flexible, locally driven approaches, the international community can play a more meaningful role in sustaining women's public participation in Afghanistan.

Do No Harm: All interventions should be risk-sensitive and designed to avoid increasing scrutiny or retaliation against Afghan women. Not all women can engage with the authorities, nor should doing so be a prerequisite for international support.

Support women's networks and build capacity for negotiation: Provide discreet funding for women's support networks that facilitate knowledge-sharing and collective bargaining strategies and strengthen coalition-building among women-led initiatives.

Adapt aid to sectoral and local variations: Align funding with areas where women can still operate, such as private enterprise, vocational training, and healthcare. Tailor interventions to local enforcement realities, recognising variations and fluidity in enforcement.

Prioritise flexible, discreet funding: Avoid high-profile initiatives that increase scrutiny and risk for Afghan women. Instead, explore low-visibility funding channels, such as cash-based assistance or local partnerships.

Fund third-Party support for engagement: Support Afghan-led facilitation on issues of mutual interest. Create or support diplomatic mechanisms that allow Afghan women to feed into international negotiations with the Taliban without direct exposure.

For further information:

Sana Tariq, Lead Researcher,
tariq@armedgroupscentre.org

Ashley Jackson, Co-Director,
jackson@armedgroupscentre.org